

What's for Me?

You have two choices for multiplayer online gaming—browser-based games and stand-alone games. Browser-based games are those played within your browser, e.g., the games you play at Yahoo! Games. Make do with these if you have a low-end system, or aren't interested in big games. What's more, you can minimise them in a fraction of a second, and bring up your work document if the boss passes your desk! On the other hand, if stunning graphics and great sound is what you're looking for, and you have a high-end machine to boot, then play stand-alone games such as *Halo*. Do keep in mind that browser-based games are the only option if you have a slow Internet connection.

and monitor multiplayer game servers for many popular online games. Those who run Linux can use XQF (www.linuxgames.com/xqf/), a game server browser and launcher that supports many popular games such as the *Quake* series, *Unreal Tournament*, *Half-Life*, etc.

You can also use your Web browser and go to specific sites to find the nearest servers. Web sites such as Moritt (<http://www.moritt.tv/UT2003>), which are dedicated to a specific games—*Unreal Tournament 2003* in this case—maintain a huge list of game servers. You can get the IP address and port from the site and use the game's multiplayer option to connect to it. You can also visit GameServers (http://gameservers.net/overview_clans.php) to find a list of such servers. However, none of these sites provide a region-wise list of servers.

Desi game servers

Multiplayer online gaming is still in its nascent stage. There aren't many game servers in India, but hopefully this will change soon. Frag-Shak (www.frag-shak.com) is one server that is located in Mumbai. Players from Mumbai can get ping times as low as 10 ms here. However, this service is not free—you need to pay a small fee of Rs 70 a month. It supports games such as *Quake III*, *Counter-Strike*, etc. You can download a client that tells you the currently available servers and their ping times.

For those living in North India, there is a site called Kawabonka (www.kawabonka.com) that has servers located in New

Delhi. Dedicated servers are available for many First Person Shooter games such as *Unreal Tournament*, *Quake III Arena*, *Counter-Strike*, etc. Non-dedicated servers for many other games are also available. The best news: these servers are free!

Play it slow

Not all games need high FPS rates, or even have real-time capabilities. Chess, for example, is a game that many people love to take their time with, and some can take upwards of an hour to calculate a move. For such games, a slower paced interaction is quite sufficient. This is where Play By E-mail (PBeM, or just PBM) comes in. You can play chess by e-mailing your move to your opponent, and he e-mails his counter move back to you. Many other games can also be played this way. Sites such as PBeM (www.pbem.com) and PBM (http://www.pbm.com/~lindahl/pbm_list/) are dedicated to them.

When a new strategy game is started, the situation, surroundings and options are announced by the game master. To join a game, you have to send an e-mail to the game master, and describe the character you want to play. After your request is approved, you can e-mail what you want your character to do in the given situation. After all the players have made their moves, the game master e-mails each player the current situation and all the players then make their next move. These sort of games are perfect for those who can't afford to spend more than a few minutes at a time playing a game.

Summing up

The best thing about the Internet is that it has something for everyone: if you're an avid gamer, you can play almost all of your favourite games with players around the world; if you only play occasionally, there are tonnes of browser-based games for you out there; you can also play games with your friends using the IMVironments of Yahoo! Messenger and MSN Messenger 6; and if you only have e-mail access, you can still play PBeM games. So go on out there, get rid of that boredom and play *TicTacToe* with your friends on MSN Messenger, or frag some dude in *Quake III*. There's just one rule... Have fun! Happy gaming! 

UPENDRA SINGHAI

upendra_singhai@thinkdigit.com

1 col AD